# UNIT ONE
## 1.1. Sentence Errors

Sentence errors can significantly impede the clarity, coherence, and effectiveness of written communication. Mastering the identification and correction of these errors is essential for academic, professional, and everyday writing. This guide provides a detailed explanation of four principal types of sentence errors: **fragments, run-on sentences, comma splices, and misplaced modifiers**.

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# 1. Sentence Fragments (Incomplete Sentences)

### Definition

A **sentence fragment** is a group of words that does not form a complete sentence because it lacks one or more essential components: a subject, a verb, or a complete thought. Such fragments create confusion by presenting incomplete or disconnected ideas.

### Causes of Sentence Fragments

1. **Dependent Clauses as Independent Sentences**
   Dependent clauses provide additional information but cannot stand alone as complete sentences.
- *Example: Because the experiment failed. (This clause leaves the reader wondering what happened due to the failure.)*
- *Revised: The project was delayed because the experiment failed.*
2. **Missing Subject**
   A sentence requires a subject to indicate who or what is performing the action.
- *Example: Ran the statistical analysis. (The subject is missing; it is unclear who performed the action.)*
- *Revised: The research assistant ran the statistical analysis.*
3. **Missing Verb**
   A verb is essential to convey an action or state of being.
- *Example: The significance of the findings. (This phrase lacks a verb, making it incomplete.)*
- *Revised: The significance of the findings was discussed in the meeting.*
4. **Phrase Fragments**
   Sometimes, prepositional phrases or other word groups are mistakenly treated as sentences.

- *Example: In the middle of the presentation. (This is a prepositional phrase, not a complete sentence.)*
- *Revised: The microphone malfunctioned in the middle of the presentation.*

### Methods for Correcting Sentence Fragments

- Attach the fragment to a nearby sentence if it logically relates to that sentence.
- Add the missing subject, verb, or both to complete the idea.
- Reorganize the sentence structure to form an independent clause.

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## 2. Run-On Sentences (Fused Sentences)

### Definition

A **run-on sentence** occurs when two or more independent clauses are improperly joined without the necessary punctuation or conjunctions. Run-on sentences disrupt the logical flow of ideas and cause comprehension difficulties.

**Fused Sentences**

Fused sentences are formed when independent clauses are combined with no punctuation or conjunction.

- *Example: The research was completed and the results were published.*
- *Revised: The research was completed, and the results were published.*

### Causes of Run-On Sentences

- Over-reliance on comma usage to join ideas.
- Misunderstanding the roles of coordinating and subordinating conjunctions.
- Lack of awareness of sentence boundaries when ideas are closely related.

### Strategies for Correcting Run-On Sentences

- Insert a period to divide the independent clauses into separate sentences.
- Use a semicolon if the clauses are closely related and of equal importance.
- Add a comma followed by a coordinating conjunction (*and, but, or, nor, for, so, yet*) to connect the clauses correctly.

**Example:**

- *Incorrect: The report was incomplete and the deadline was approaching.*
- *Correct: The report was incomplete, so the team worked overtime to finish it.*

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# 3. Comma Splices

### Definition

A **comma splice** occurs when two independent clauses are joined solely by a comma without an appropriate coordinating conjunction. This error creates ambiguity and disrupts the flow of information.

### Causes of Comma Splices

- The assumption that a comma alone suffices to connect related ideas.
- Misapplication of punctuation rules.

### Examples of Comma Splices and Their Revisions

1. *Comma Splice: The lecture was engaging, the students asked many questions.*
    - *Revised: The lecture was engaging, and the students asked many questions. (Comma + Coordinating Conjunction)*
    - *Alternative: The lecture was engaging; the students asked many questions. (Semicolon)*
2. *Comma Splice: The software update was released, users reported several issues.*
    - *Revised: The software update was released. Users reported several issues. (Period + New Sentence)*

### Methods for Correcting Comma Splices

- Replace the comma with a period to separate the clauses into distinct sentences.
- Insert a semicolon between the clauses if they convey closely related ideas.
- Add a comma along with a coordinating conjunction to correctly join the independent clauses.

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# 4. Misplaced and Dangling Modifiers

### Definition

A **modifier** is a word, phrase, or clause that provides additional information about another element in a sentence. **Misplaced modifiers** appear too far from the word they modify, while **dangling modifiers** are disconnected from any clear referent.

### Types of Modifier Errors

1. **Misplaced Modifiers**
   When a modifier is incorrectly positioned, the sentence's meaning can become ambiguous or unintentionally humorous.
- *Example: She served sandwiches to the children on paper plates. (Who was on the plates—children or sandwiches?)*
- *Revised: She served sandwiches on paper plates to the children.*
2. **Dangling Modifiers**
   A dangling modifier occurs when the word it describes is missing from the sentence.
- *Example: After analyzing the data, the conclusion was clear. (Who analyzed the data?)*
- *Revised: After analyzing the data, the researchers concluded that the results were significant.*

### Causes of Modifier Errors

- Incomplete sentence construction where the subject is implied but not stated.
- Misplacement of descriptive words due to unclear sentence structure.

### Strategies for Correcting Modifier Errors

- Position modifiers as closely as possible to the words they describe.
- Ensure that the subject of the sentence is explicitly mentioned.
- Reconstruct the sentence if necessary to clarify relationships between words.

**Example:**

- *Incorrect: Driving down the street, the flowers were beautiful. (Who was driving?)*
- *Correct: Driving down the street, she admired the beautiful flowers.*

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# Conclusion

Sentence errors—fragments, run-ons, comma splices, and misplaced or dangling modifiers—pose significant challenges to written communication. Understanding the rules governing sentence structure and applying appropriate corrections enables writers to convey ideas with clarity, precision, and professionalism.

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# References


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